

Optilume Drug-Coated Balloon

Patient Information · A balloon-and-medicine treatment for a urethral narrowing

WARWIKI

Optilume treats a narrowing (a stricture) of the urethra, the tube that carries urine out of your body. A balloon widens the narrow spot. At the same time, it puts a medicine into the wall to help keep scar from closing it again. It is done through the urethra, with no outside cut.

About This Procedure

A urethral **stricture** is a scarred, narrow part that slows the urine stream. Stretching or cutting it through a scope often lets it narrow again. Optilume does two things at once:

- A **balloon widens** the scarred part.
- A **medicine coating (paclitaxel)** on the balloon goes into the tissue to slow new scar.

It is approved for men with a narrowing **3 cm or shorter** in the front part of the urethra. It is used most for a narrowing under the scrotum that **came back after earlier stretches or cuts**. It works better than another plain stretch. It does **not replace urethroplasty** (open repair), and the two have not been compared directly. Your surgeon will explain where it fits for you.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

3 in 4

men had an open urethra 6 months after Optilume

about
1 in 4

had an open urethra 6 months after another plain stretch or cut

up to
7 in 10

needed no further procedure 3 years after Optilume

Numbers are averages from published studies. The 3-year Optilume figure may be high: some men whose narrowing came back did not have another procedure. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

Who Should Not Have It

Optilume is not used if you have a **penile implant** or an **artificial urinary sphincter**, or an **allergy to paclitaxel**. A urine infection must be treated first. It was not tested in men with lichen sclerosus or an earlier urethroplasty or hypospadias repair. If the narrowing comes back after Optilume, a second balloon is not usually advised. Your team may talk with you about open repair.

Learn the Terms

Urethra

The tube that carries urine out of the body.

Stricture

A scarred, narrow spot in the urethra that slows the urine stream.

Bulbar urethra

The part of the urethra under the scrotum, where this treatment is used most.

Drug-coated balloon

A balloon that widens the narrowing and puts medicine into the wall.

Paclitaxel

The medicine on the balloon. It helps keep the scar from coming back.

Dilation

Widening a narrowing. Here, it is done with the balloon.

Cystoscope

A thin camera used to find and check the narrowing.

Catheter

A soft tube placed in the urethra for a few days after the procedure.

Will it hurt? You are asleep or sedated, so you feel nothing during it. Afterward, expect mild burning, an ache in the penis or pelvis, and some blood in the urine or semen for a short time. Many people go home the same day.

First days

A catheter stays in for at least 2 days. Your team tells you when it comes out.

First 30 days

No sex, or use a condom every time.

First 6 months

Do not father a child for at least 6 months. Use highly effective birth control.

Follow-up

Checks of your urine flow. Tell your team if it slows again.

How to Get Ready

- Follow your instructions about eating, drinking and which medicines to stop, including blood thinners.
- A **urine test** checks for infection. Any infection is treated first.
- **Arrange a ride home.**

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Take a **blood thinner**
- Have a penile implant or artificial sphincter
- Hope to **father a child** in the next 6 months

What Happens During the Procedure

- 1 A thin camera checks the length and place of the narrowing.
- 2 A thin wire is passed across it, and the area is stretched enough to fit the balloon.
- 3 The balloon is filled across the scar for several minutes to deliver the medicine.
- 4 The balloon is removed, and a catheter is placed.

After the Procedure

- Mild burning and pink urine or semen are common for a few days. Drinking extra water helps.
- The medicine can be in your semen for months. That is why the condom and birth-control steps matter.

Call the office that did your procedure if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Pain that gets worse instead of better
- A weaker urine stream after it had improved

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate after the catheter is out and your bladder feels full or painful
- Heavy bleeding, or urine like red wine or with clots
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Optilume widens a narrow urethra and adds medicine to slow new scar. It does not replace open repair.
2. No sex or a condom for 30 days. Do not father a child for at least 6 months.
3. Tell your team if your stream slows again.